Helping students participate in group work

Practical guide for subject lecturers | D08-S1–S6

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Group work requires students to understand the task, express ideas, follow others' contributions and reach decisions together. Make these processes explicit so students know how to contribute.

1. Make the task and expected contribution clear

Display the group's goal, time available and required output. Explain what each member should contribute and how those contributions will help the group complete the task.

Example — Business

"You have 12 minutes to compare two proposals and recommend one. Each person should contribute at least one strength or limitation. Submit a shared recommendation with two reasons, using evidence from the case."

Before students begin, ask:

- *"What will your group submit?"*
- *"What should each person prepare?"*

Keep the instructions visible throughout the activity.

2. Give individual preparation time

Before discussion, give everyone a short period to develop an initial contribution.

Ask students to note an idea, question or piece of evidence. Keywords, diagrams or annotations are sufficient.

Example — Public health

"Take two minutes to identify one benefit and one limitation of the intervention. Mark the evidence you used. You will compare your ideas with the group."

This gives each student something to bring to the discussion. They can revise their ideas after hearing others.

3. Structure opportunities for everyone to contribute

Begin with a brief sharing round before opening the discussion.

How to do it

1. Give individual preparation time.
2. Ask each member to share one initial idea.
3. Ask others to listen without interrupting.
4. Allow anyone who needs more time to return later in the round.
5. Open the discussion for comparison, questions and evaluation.

Example — Engineering

"First, each person suggests one possible cause of the fault. Listen to all the suggestions before evaluating them. Then compare them against the test results."

Explain that everyone should have an opportunity to contribute, but contributions do not need to be equally long.

4. Assign useful roles and rotate them

Choose roles that help students complete the task. Describe the actions involved rather than giving students a title alone.

Role	What the student does
Facilitator	Keeps the group focused, invites contributions and checks that members can follow the discussion.
Evidence checker	Asks which data or course concepts support the group's claims.
Recorder	Records the main reasons, decisions and unresolved questions.
Reporter	Explains the group's conclusion and reasoning to the class.

Use only the roles the task needs. Combine roles in smaller groups and rotate them across activities.

Example — Environmental science

"The evidence checker should ask us to connect each recommendation to the case data. Everyone still helps evaluate the evidence."

Avoid repeatedly assigning a student the recorder role because they are less confident speaking English.

5. Model language for working together

Display a few optional phrases suited to the activity. Demonstrate how students can use them with subject content.

Purpose	*Possible wording*
Join the discussion	"Can I add a point?"
Build on an idea	"That connects to… because…"
Ask for evidence	"What evidence supports that?"
Disagree constructively	"I see your point, but…"
Check meaning	"Do you mean that…?"
Invite a contribution	"Would you like to add anything?"

Example — Economics

- **Student A:** "I think transport costs explain the price increase."
- **Student B:** "What evidence supports that?"
- **Student A:** "The case says fuel costs rose."
- **Student C:** "I see your point, but wages also increased. We should consider both."

Explain that students can use their own wording. The phrases help them carry out the discussion; they are not a script to memorise.

6. Monitor how the group is working

Circulate and listen to both the subject discussion and how members are participating.

Check:

- Does everyone understand the task?
- Can members follow the discussion?
- Are ideas being considered and supported with evidence?
- Is anyone repeatedly interrupted or excluded?

Give the group a specific action when help is needed.

If one person dominates: "Pause there. Give everyone a moment to prepare, then invite any ideas we have not heard yet."

If members have lost track: "Summarise the options so far. Check that everyone understands them before deciding."

If the group divides the work without discussing it: "Before combining your answers, explain your reasoning to each other and check whether the parts fit together."

Finish with a brief reflection: "What helped your group use everyone's ideas? What will you change next time?"

A short routine to try

For one group task:

1. Display the goal and required output.
2. Give two minutes of individual preparation.
3. Begin with one contribution from each member.
4. Use roles where they help.
5. Monitor and support the discussion.
6. Ask for the group's conclusion and a brief reflection.

Supporting sources

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